Door From the Shrine of Sayyida Zaynab

Shrine of Sayyida Zaynab, Cairo

Khedival, late 13th - early 14th centuries AH / mid- to late 19th century CE

Wood and Brass

W: 250 cm; H: 320 cm

Hall 1

Inv. no. 1066



The front façade of the door © NADIM Foundation

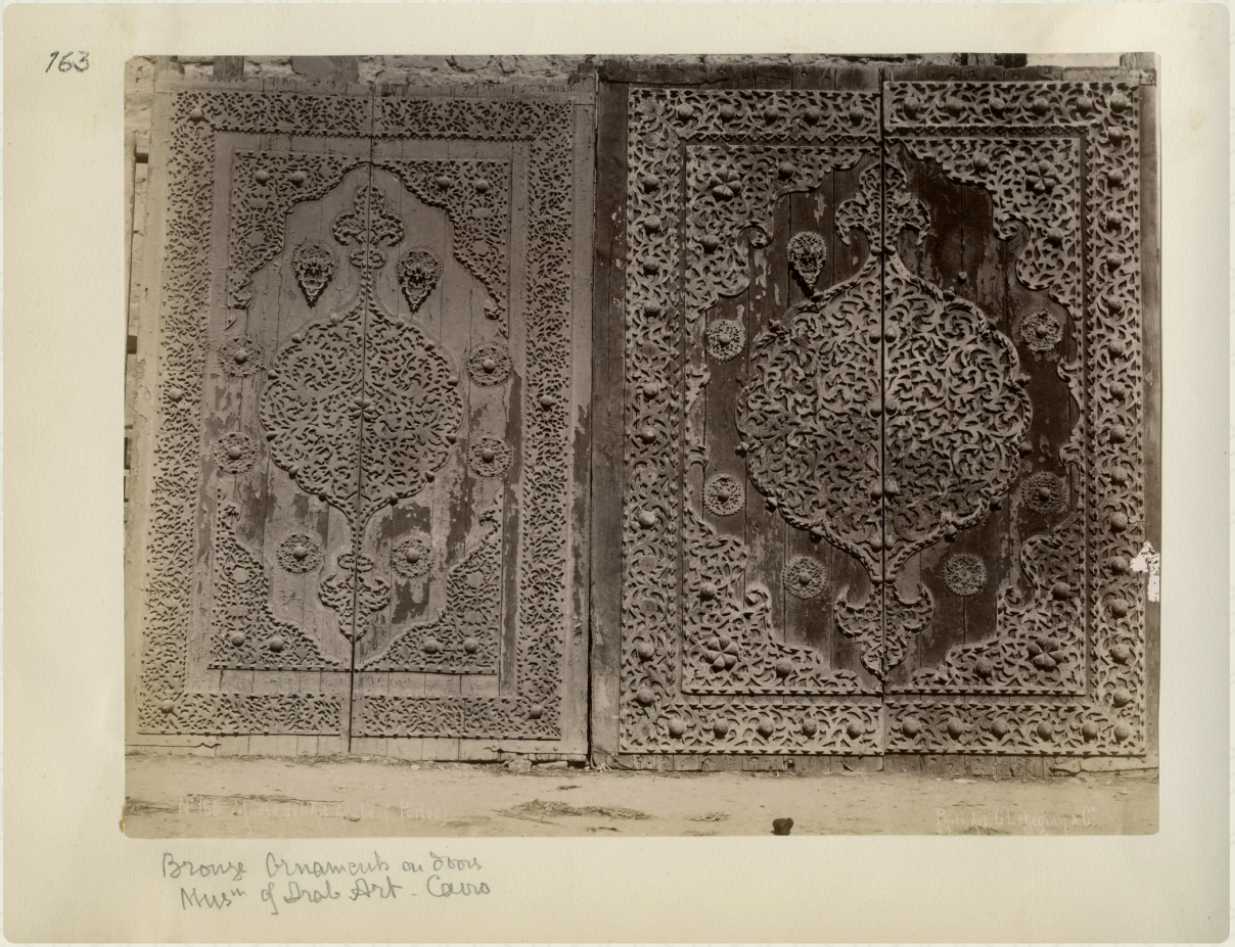
This metal-revetted door comes from the mosque-mausoleum of Sayyida Zaynab, granddaughter of the Prophet Muhammad and daughter of Ali ibn Abi Talib, She is a figure profoundly embedded in Egypt's devotional landscape. Revered as a member of the Ahl al-Bayt, Sayyida Zaynab was celebrated under numerous honorifics - including ʿAqilat Banu Hashim ("the most discerning noblewoman of the Banu

Hashim"), Ra'isat al-Diwan ("head of the court"), Sahibat al-Shura ("mistress of council"), Umm al-'Awagiz ("mother of the helpless"), and Umm al-Masa'ib ("mother of misfortune") - each reflecting the moral authority and spiritual compassion attributed to her across centuries.



Mosque of of Sayyida Zaynab in the 19th century

Her shrine underwent an unusually dense sequence of restorations from the Ayyubid period onwards, with particularly ambitious campaigns in the eighteenth and nineteenth centuries. The present door likely belongs to these later phases, when contemporary accounts record the installation and renewal of conspicuous brass doors. Its attribution is framed by the contrasting artistic climates cultivated under Khedive Isma'il (r. 1863-79), whose expansive patronage embraced European models, and Khedive Tawfiq (r. 1879-92), under whom architectural intervention increasingly aligned with conservation and emerging notions of national identity.



Door of the Sayyeda Zainab mosque, photographed by G. Lekegian at the Museum of Islamic Art, c.1900. Reproduced with permission of the Griffith Institute, University of Oxford.

Stylistically, the door presents a layered synthesis of traditions. A photograph by Armenian photographer Gabriel Lekegian from the early-20th century shows it among related examples once held by the Museum of Islamic Art, Cairo. Its central bukhariyya medallion belongs to a Mamluk ornamental vocabulary that remained current into the early modern period, while the surrounding vegetal decoration - sinuous, curling, and wave-like in character, with Chinese-Ilkhanid lotuses and chrysanthemums - departs from classical arabesque in favor of rumi-forms associated with Ottoman taste and ultimately derived from Anatolian Seljuk models. European influence is evident in the bulbous six-petalled corner rosettes, the prominent rounded nails securing the metal revetment, and the festoon-like ornament encircling the bukhariyya, as well as in the use of shell-shaped, teardrop, and diamond-headed nails in place of the fluted fasteners typical of Mamluk doors. The stepped-arched motif repeating along the inner frame recalls in particular the fluted stone decoration of the keel-arched entrance portal of al-Aqmar mosque (1125 CE). Despite its richness, the absence of inscriptions suggests that the door did not serve as a principal entrance; its original knockers, now lost, are

preserved in early photographs. Taken together, these features situate the door at the intersection of Mamluk legacy, Khedieval rule, and nineteenth-century European influence, embodying a palimpsest of artistic traditions within one of Cairo's most venerated shrines.

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